



against weaker sides but vulnerability against equals.

In the Super 4s, India's fortunes swung back and forth. A rain-hit 4-2 win over Korea briefly raised hopes, only for a 4-1 loss to China to bring it crashing down. A draw with Japan left qualification for the final hanging on China's result against Korea; when that fell India's way, another shot at World Cup qualification beckoned. But the team couldn't seize it.

Still, the final offered encouragement. India stunned China with a first-minute goal, only for the host to settle quickly, push back with control, and underline the gulf between the two teams. It was India's best performance of the tournament, yet the difference in class was unmistakable — evident in the world rankings too, with China at No. 4 and India at No. 10.

For China, the triumph was almost inevitable. Ranked fourth in the world, fresh from a silver medal at the Paris Olympics, and having plundered 38 goals in six games before the final, including a 20-0 demolition of Taiwan,



Stability restored: Udit Duhan's return plugged gaps in India's defence and midfield.

SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

the Chinese were always favourites. India, by contrast, had stumbled through a nervy campaign, needing other results to fall its way. That it still emerged second was commendable.

The result gives Harendra Singh and his players a boost ahead of the all-important World Cup qualifiers in early 2026. It also rekindles hope that India can re-establish itself as Asia's second force behind China, ahead of Japan and Korea. Challenges remain: relegation from the Pro League has complicated preparations, but Harendra is pushing for at least five or six high-quality friendlies against European teams. The upcoming Hockey India League will be another key step in testing combinations before the qualifiers.

Big setback: Deepika did not travel with the national team to China for the Women's Asia Cup due to a hamstring injury. R.V. MOORTHY